

Pakistan: Law formalizes Munir's military grip

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【メール原文】

The newly passed Defence Forces Act 2026 legally entrenches Field Marshal Asim Munir's command over the military and national security apparatus, redu|||||||

Quick take

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Munir's centralization of power entrenches miliary authority in law

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What Happened

Pakistan's parliament passed the Defence Forces Act 2026 on 20 August, centralizing military authority under Field Marshal Asim Munir. Munir now exercises operational command over the three military services, heads the new Defence Forces Headquarters, and serves as the prime minister's principal military adviser. He also has complete personal power over the careers of individual military personnel, including the authority to retire or discharge officers.

Our Take

The legislation formalizes Munir's considerable informal influence. The new act legally implements changes introduced through the 27th Constitutional Amendment under which the army chief also became the chief of defence forces (CDF) (see: Military control of judiciary will further complicate revenue targets , 25 November 2025). Because the CDF role has been combined with army leadership, it reinforces the army's supremacy rather than creating a balanced joint command. The government says the restructuring is a reaction to the demands of modern warfare and the need for integrated operations across all domains, including cyber. Accompanying amendments align Pakistan's nuclear command system with this new hierarchy.

The move toward an institutionalized model of military leadership could bring near-term stability. The new act sharply reduces the ability of civilian politicians to influence national security, foreign policy, and internal security decisions. Future governments may retain formal authority over appointments and policy, but challenging the CDF will be increasingly difficult. Political parties have already become accustomed to seeking accommodation with the military rather than relying on parliament and democratic consensus. Munir's control over officers' careers will also curb internal dissent within the military.

The new structure could produce short-term stability and a more coherent defense policy. However, it drastically weakens civilian ministries, parliamentary oversight, and institutional accountability. It moves Pakistan closer to institutionalized military rule and away from the current informal hybrid system.

Munir likely to use popularity to redraw internal borders and reduce threats from provincial leaders. The new law comes as Munir is riding the crest of popularity gained from his role in mediating the Iran conflict and concluding a defense pact with Saudi Arabia and Turkey. While the economy is still weak and ethnic protests are spreading (see: Sharif government will weather Kashmiri protests amid fragmented provincial unrest , 14 August 2026), Munir has remained politically unscathed.

Munir is likely to use his enhanced authority to advance an ambitious plan to reorganize Pakistan's provincial borders and create over two dozen new provinces. This would check the rise of powerful civilian politicians. It could yield administrative gains by reducing the clout of the two largest provinces, Punjab and Sindh, but could also make it harder to get a consensus on national policies.

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